

A matter of perception

A while ago, we'd done a cover story on an esoteric practice gadget makers routinely engage in called planned obsolescence. It's esoteric, not because it's actually unknown to consumers – of course the smarter lot amongst you know that companies build in systems that are rigged to fail after a certain number of operations, or that they already have the tech required to come up with a better, more powerful line of products at any given moment but deliberately choose to delay the deployment of those technologies because they haven't milked the outgoing line dry to their heart's content. No, that's not the reason I call it esoteric, because you know all this. Or at least have an inkling of it when you set out to buy, say, a new phone to replace the one that stopped working just one day after the warranty expired. Funny how that happens, eh?

What's esoteric about planned obsolescence is that there's an actual term for it, and that companies have actual roadmaps and succession plans based on it. It's not a conspiracy theory, it's considered perfectly acceptable corporate strategy. The lifespan of products isn't discussed on the merit of durability, but on factors dictated purely by profit. They even have research reports based on which they'll decide the optimal time frame within which to launch a successor product that'll serve no other purpose than to make the older one obsolete. We've already told you all this before, through a rather controversial cover story titled F**k You Consumers.

What we probably didn't tell you about was perceived obsolescence, a slightly more ambiguous practice which is a subset of planned obsolescence. What makes it ambiguous or more absurd is that it is not a one-sided phenomenon. Consumers are as responsible for it as the manufacturers themselves. In simple terms, perceived obsolescence is an effect that kicks in when a newer shinier gadget is released, and all of a sudden your older perfectly working device starts to look less desirable.

Take my case for example. I have an older generation Kindle Paperwhite 3G that works perfectly fine. But when I gifted my sister a latest generation Paperwhite with an upgraded PPI, all I could think was, "Ooh that looks nice. Maybe I should buy one myself." I grabbed the device from her hands as soon as she finished

tearing through the gift wrapping and compared it to my older "meagre" 212 PPI Kindle Paperwhite, much to my sister's annoyance. It was better for sure, but not that great either.

A product category in which perceived obsolescence is most conspicuous is mobile phones. Upgrades aren't always dictated by functionality or a performance deficit necessitating an upgrade. It's all about having the latest generation device for the sake of having a latest gen device and then there's the flaunt value as well. Apple often epitomises this phenomenon because, hey, you know as well as I that you bought the iPhone 5S to replace your perfectly functioning iPhone 5 for flaunting that gold back.

Now before you get your pitchforks out or label us *Digit-walas* Apple haters, let me clarify. This is not an Apple bashing column. In fact, I think Apple has deviated from its standard modus operandi when it comes to the recently launched iPhone 6s and 6s Plus. Keeping the current versions nearly indistinguishable from their predecessors, Apple has sort of negated the flaunt value motivation that forms a basis for perceived obsolescence. Don't get me wrong, I'm not under the Apple spell. We've done our share of "Apple copied this feature from so and so" articles online. But the thing is this 3D Touch business seems really promising. At the time of writing this the first few reviews of the phones have come out. Despite the lack of apps utilising this ability to vary interface behaviour through a pressure-sensitive touchscreen, the potential it entails for games and text input seems, well, for lack of a better word, promising. I think for the first time Apple doesn't seem to rely on the perceived obsolescence hysteria. But that's just an opinion. Do you think I'm being objective, or am I just creating justifications for my latent Apple craving? 🍏




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